

SAM PRATT

PhD Student in Psychology · University of California, Los Angeles

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[Google Scholar](#)

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EDUCATION

- 2025 – **University of California, Los Angeles**
PhD in Psychology
Advisor: Dr. Matthew Lieberman
- 2019 – 2023 **Harvard University**
B.A. in Psychology, Magna Cum Laude with Highest Honors
GPA: 3.97

PEER-REVIEWED PUBLICATIONS

- Pratt, S.**, Jones, P. J., Bellet, B. W., McNally, R. J., & Gray, K. (2026). The words can harm scale: Measuring beliefs about harmful speech. *Personality and Individual Differences*, 257. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.paid.2026.113785>
- Womick, J., Kubin, E., Goya-Tocchetto, D., Ochoa, N. R., Rebollar, C., Kapsaskis, K., **Pratt, S.**, Devine, H., Payne, B. K., Vaisey, S., & Gray, K. (2026). Liberals and conservatives see different victims: Moral disagreement is explained by different assumptions of vulnerability. *Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin*. <https://doi.org/10.1177/01461672261422957>
- Pratt, S.**, Rosenfeld, D. L., Goranson, A., Tomiyama, A. J., Sheeran, P., & Gray, K. (2025). Health behaviors are moralized when perceived to cause harm. *Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin*. <https://doi.org/10.1177/01461672251372823>
- Pratt, S.***, Jones, P. J.*, Bridgland, V. M. E., Bellet, B. W., & McNally, R. J. (2025). Sending signals: Trigger warnings and safe space notifications. *Journal of Experimental Psychology: Applied*. Advance online publication. <https://doi.org/10.1037/xap0000541> †
- Gray, K., & **Pratt, S.** (2025). Morality in our mind and across cultures and politics. *Annual Review of Psychology*, 76, 663–691. <https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev-psych-020924-124236>
- Worsnip, A., Lane, D., **Pratt, S.**, Napolitano, G. M., Gray, K., & Greene, J. A. (2025). Authority or autonomy? Philosophical and psychological perspectives on deference to experts. *Philosophical Psychology*, 1–36. <https://doi.org/10.1080/09515089.2025.2475138>
- Rodriguez, M., **Pratt, S.**, Bellet, B. W., & McNally, R. J. (2023). Solitude can be good—if you see it as such: Reappraisal helps lonely people experience solitude more positively. *Journal of Personality*, 93(1), 118–135. <https://doi.org/10.1111/jopy.12887> ‡

* These authors contributed equally to this work.

† Selected as an Editor's Choice paper in *JEP: Applied*.

‡ Recognized as a top 10 Most Cited and top 10% Most Viewed article of 2023 by the *Journal of Personality*.

MANUSCRIPTS UNDER REVIEW AND PREPRINTS

Bridgland, V. M. E., Jones, P. J., Bellet, B. W., **Pratt, S.**, & McNally, R. J. (2026). The art of harm reduction: The effect of trigger warnings and framing statements on reactions to artwork.

Pratt, S., Bellet, B. W., Jones, P. J., & McNally, R. J. (2024). Testing the coddling hypothesis: Campus safetyism and student resilience. *PsyArXiv*. <https://doi.org/10.31234/osf.io/zav5g>

Sarkar, A., Sella, F., Rebollar, C., Ibata, N. G. O., **Pratt, S.**, Kahane, G., Gray, K., Savulescu, J., Elliot, A. J., & Thompson, J. M. (2025). Social impressions shape moral decisions.

MANUSCRIPTS IN PREPARATION

Bai, F., Chan, S., Dong, Y., Tierney, W., Celniker, J., **Pratt, S.**, Gray, K., Clark, C. J., ... & Uhlmann, E. L. (2024). Person-centered moral judgments: Replicability, cross-cultural generalizability, and theoretical integration. Ongoing large-scale project.

FELLOWSHIPS AND GRANTS

2026	NSF Graduate Research Fellowship Program (GRFP) awardee
2026	UCLA Graduate Research Mentorship Award (\$30,000)
2026	UCLA Graduate Summer Research Mentorship Award (\$6,000)
2025	Edwin W. Pauley Award (\$30,000), awarded to two incoming Psychology PhD students at UCLA
2024	Harvard Institute for Quantitative Social Science Grant (\$16,000)
2022	Harvard College Research Program Grant (\$5,000) for senior honors thesis
2022	Harvard College Research Program Grant (\$1,000) for senior honors thesis
2021	Harvard College Research Program Grant (\$1,000) for independent research

HONORS AND AWARDS

2026	2025 Early Career Award , Society for Experimental Psychology and Cognitive Science (APA Division 3) Awarded unanimously by the editors of the <i>Journal of Experimental Psychology</i> for one of the year's most outstanding empirical papers by a new scholar: <i>Sending Signals: Trigger Warnings and Safe Space Notifications</i> .
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2025	Editor's Choice Award , <i>Journal of Experimental Psychology: Applied</i> For <i>Sending Signals: Trigger Warnings and Safe Space Notifications</i> .
2025	NSF Graduate Research Fellowship Program , Honorable Mention
2023	Phi Beta Kappa , awarded to top 10% of graduating class, Harvard University
2023	Summa Cum Laude , Senior Honors Thesis in Psychology, Harvard University
2023	Psychology Faculty Prize for outstanding senior honors thesis, Harvard University
2023	Highest Honors in the field of Psychology, Harvard University
2023	Seamus P. Malin Award , for outstanding teamwork and dedication to Harvard Men's Soccer
2022	John Harvard Scholar , awarded to the top 5% of junior class, Harvard University
2021	John Harvard Scholar , awarded to the top 5% of sophomore class, Harvard University
2020	Academic All-Ivy League , awarded to one member of each varsity sports team, Harvard University

INVITED TALKS

Jul 2026	Pratt, S. <i>Becoming a psychological scientist</i> . Invited talk presented in person to the Advanced Studies Program at St. Paul's School, Concord, New Hampshire.
Jun 2025	Pratt, S. <i>How camp shapes us: The psychology of belonging</i> . Invited talk presented in person at YMCA Camp Belknap, Wolfeboro, New Hampshire.
Apr 2025	Pratt, S. & Kubin, E. <i>Testing true victimhood beliefs across cultures and contexts</i> . Invited talk presented in person at the Templeton World Charity Foundation grant cohort meeting, Listening and Learning in a Polarized World, Marrakesh, Morocco.
Oct 2024	Pratt, S. & Gray, K. <i>The roots of moral disagreement and how to find common ground</i> . Invited talk presented virtually at St. Paul's School, Concord, New Hampshire.

CONFERENCE POSTERS

May 2026	Pratt, S. , Rosenfeld, D. L., Goranson, A., Tomiyama, A. J., Sheeran, P., & Gray, K. <i>Health behaviors are moralized when perceived to cause harm</i> . Poster presented by S. Pratt at the annual convention for the Association for Psychological Science (Barcelona, Spain).
Feb 2024	Pratt, S. & Gray, K. <i>Harm denial: A source of political animosity and a potential solution</i> . Poster presented by S. Pratt at the annual convention for the Society of Personality and Social Psychology (San Diego, CA).
Aug 2023	Pratt, S. , Rodriguez, M., Bellet, B. W., & McNally, R. J. <i>Alone but not lonely: Brief cognitive interventions for lonely individuals</i> . Poster presented by S. Pratt at the annual convention for the American Psychological Association (Washington, D.C.).

Feb 2023

Pratt, S., Rodriguez, M., Bellet, B. W., & McNally, R. J. *Alone but not lonely: Cognitive reappraisal helps lonely individuals experience time alone more positively.* Poster presented by S. Pratt at the annual convention for the Society of Personality and Social Psychology (Atlanta, GA).

PUBLIC SCHOLARSHIP

EDITED BOOKS

Gray, K. (2025, January 14). *Outraged: Why we fight about morality and politics and how to find common ground.* Pantheon. Assisted with research, writing, and editing.

PODCASTS

Guest, *Outrage Overload Podcast*. Episode 63: Moral psychology and the harm-based roots of political polarization. Interviewed by David Beckemeyer. April 30, 2025. [Listen](#)

SCIENCE WRITING

Pratt, S. (2026, May). [If we're so smart, why aren't we rich?](#) *Train of Thought*.

Pratt, S. (2026, April). [Most students want trigger warnings: They don't actually help.](#) *The Science Matters*.

Pratt, S. (2026, March). [Can words harm? My new measure that sparked Twitter outrage.](#) *Train of Thought*.

Pratt, S., Jones, P., & Bridgland, V. (2025, September). [Want a more supportive classroom? Skip the trigger warning.](#) *SPSP Character & Context Blog*.

Gray, K., Devine, H., & **Pratt, S.** (2025, April). [Strip club physics: Serious decisions need serious settings.](#) *The Moral Understanding Substack*.

Gray, K., **Pratt, S.**, & Devine, H. (2025, February). [AI is more moral than you \(and the NYTimes' best ethicist\).](#) *The Moral Understanding Substack*.

Gray, K., & **Pratt, S.** (2025, January). [Why grandma's cookies taste so good \(or: When I gave electric shocks to Harvard undergraduates\).](#) *The Moral Understanding Substack*.

Gray, K., **Pratt, S.**, & Devine, H. (2024, December). [How the DMV saved Christmas: Shared irritation brings us together.](#) *The Moral Understanding Substack*.

Gray, K., Devine, H., & **Pratt, S.** (2024, December). [The assassination of a CEO: Why some celebrate the pain of the powerful.](#) *The Moral Understanding Substack*.

Gray, K., **Pratt, S.**, & Devine, H. (2024, November). [In defense of flat earthers: Conspiracy theorists are more logical than you think.](#) *The Moral Understanding Substack*.

Gray, K., Devine, H., & **Pratt, S.** (2024, November). [Moving forward: The 2024 election and the curse of knowledge.](#) *The Moral Understanding Substack*.

Gray, K., Devine, H., & **Pratt, S.** (2024, October). [The psychology of pettiness: Why \(some\) people get so angry at line-cutting and grape-stealing.](#) *The Moral Understanding Substack*.

Gray, K. & **Pratt, S.** (2024, September). The problem with moral psychology: What science says about moral truths and romancing your sibling. *The Moral Understanding Substack.*

Gray, K., **Pratt, S.**, & Puryear, C. (2024, April). Danger! Why moral panics are irresistible to your brain. *The Moral Understanding Substack.*

Pratt, S. & Gray, K. (2024, February). Being alone doesn't make you a killer (or: Would Henry David Thoreau be a mass shooter in 2024?). *The Moral Understanding Substack.*

Gray, K., & **Pratt, S.** (2024, January). Hidden brain and evil explain: Lessons from death threats. *The Moral Understanding Substack.*

Rodriguez, M., **Pratt, S.**, & Bellet, B. (2023, November). Improving our relationship to being alone. *SPSP Character & Context Blog.*

Gray, K., **Pratt, S.**, & Blakey, W. (2023, October). The myopia of heroism: Hamas, Israel, and the quest to save victims. *The Moral Understanding Substack.*

Gray, K., Blakey, W., & **Pratt, S.** (2023, August). Charitable condescension: You're not a saint for thinking "they" are stupid. *The Moral Understanding Substack.*

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

2026 Spring	Teaching Assistant, PSYCH 10: Introductory Psychology, UCLA
2023 Fall	Teaching Assistant, The Science of Moral Understanding, UNC Chapel Hill
2023 Summer	Teaching Assistant, Becoming a Brain Scientist: Neuroscience and Psychology Research, Harvard Summer School

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

2023 – 2025	Lab Manager, Deepest Beliefs Lab University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill PI: Kurt Gray, PhD
2021 – 2023	Research Assistant, Laboratory for Anxiety & Related Disorders Harvard University PI: Richard J. McNally, PhD — conducted senior honors thesis
2021 Winter; 2023 Spring	Research Assistant, Laboratory on Complex Thought and Cooperation Harvard University PI: Joshua Greene, PhD
2020 Summer	Research Assistant, Laboratory for Youth Mental Health Harvard University PI: John Weisz, PhD

AFFILIATIONS AND SERVICE

- 2025 – Psychology in Action, University of California, Los Angeles
- 2024 – Advisory committee member, Institute for Multipartisan Education
- 2023 – Society for Personality and Social Psychology (SPSP)
- 2022 – 2023 Psychology Undergraduate Planning Committee, Harvard University